21.4 Tobacco Abuse

Tobacco is obtained from the tobacco plant *Nicotiana tobaccum* and *Nicotiana rustica*. The dried and cured leaves of its young branches make the commercial tobacco used worldwide. Addiction to tobacco is due to '**nicotine**' an alkaloid present in it. Nicotine is a **stimulant**, highly harmful and poisonous substance.

21.4.1 Tobacco Use

Tobacco is used for smoking, chewing and snuffing. Inhaling tobacco smoke from cigars, cigarettes, bidis, pipes, hukka is called **smoking**. Tobacco in powder form is **chewed** with pan. When powdered tobacco is taken through nose, it is called **snuffing**.

21.4.2 Smoking Hazards and Effects of Tobacco

When smoke is inhaled, the chemicals get absorbed by the tissues and cause the following harmful effects

(i) **Benzopyrene** and **polycyclic hydrocarbons** present in tobacco smoke is carcinogenic causing lung cancer.

(ii) Causes inflammation of throat and bronchi leading to conditions like **bronchitis** and **pulmonary tuberculosis.**

(iii) Inflammation of lung alveoli, decrease surface area for gas exchange and cause **emphysema.**

(iv) **Carbon monoxide** of tobacco smoke binds to haemoglobin of RBC and decreases its oxygen carrying capacity causing **hypoxia** in body tissues.

(v) **Increased blood pressure** caused by smoking leads to increased risk of heart disease.

(vi) Causes **increased gastric secretion** which leads to gastric and duodenal ulcers.

(vii) Tobacco chewing causes **oral cancer** (mouth cancer).

Info bits

World Health organization (WHO) 1984 suggested the use of the term drug. WHO issued a directive under which all cigarette advertisements and packs carry a statutory warning **"Smoking is injurious to Health".**

Activity 1

Collect pictures of people affected by tobacco chewing and tobacco smoking. Identify which part of the body is affected and the health hazards it can lead to.

21.4.3 Prevention of Smoking

Knowing the dangers of smoking and chewing tobacco adolescents and the old people need to avoid these habits. Proper counselling and medical assistance can help an addict to give up the habit of smoking.

More to Know

Anti Tobacco Act was passed on May 1st 2004. By 2030 tobacco is expected to be single biggest cause of death worldwide accounting for 10 million deaths per year.

May 31st is observed as No Tobacco Day (World Anti-Tobacco Day)







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